in Central Asia with intelligence work of his own. In Ivan Vitkevitch, he found a man who he hoped would ‘play the part of Alexander Burnes’. As soon as it became clear that the British were about to invade Afghanistan, Perovsky began lobbying to revive Russian prestige in the region by conquering the Turkman Khanate of Khiva. The Russian attack on Khiva ended as disastrously as the British retreat from Kabul would do, with Perovsky losing half his camels and nearly half his men. It put back Russian ambitions on the steppe for a generation: Khiva would not fall to Russian arms until 1872.

Ivan Vitkevitch (1806–39): He was a Roman Catholic Polish nobleman, born Jan Prosper Witkiewicz in Vilnius, today the capital of Lithuania. Jan had helped found a secret society called the Black Brothers, an underground ‘revolutionary-national’ resistance movement begun by a group of Polish students intent on fighting the Russian occupation of their country. Witkiewicz and the five other ringleaders were arrested and interrogated, stripped of their titles and rank in the nobility and sent to different fortresses on the Kazakh steppe. At the time, Witkiewicz had just celebrated his fourteenth birthday. Witkiewicz resigned himself to his fate and decided to make the best of his situation. He learned Kazakh and Chagatai Turkish, allowed his name to be changed to the more Russian-sounding Ivan Viktorovitch Vitkevitch, and rose to become the first Russian player of the Great Game. He made two expeditions to Bukhara before being sent to Kabul to make an alliance with Dost Mohammad. Here he outmanoeuvred his British rival, Alexander Burnes, but when his alliances were countermanded by his superiors, and the British invaded Afghanistan, he returned to St Petersburg where he was found dead in a hotel room on 8 May 1839, having apparently committed suicide.

Mohammad Shah II Qajar (1808–48) was the Qajar ruler of Persia who, by embracing a pro-Russian alliance and trying to recapture the disputed Afghan border town of Herat, helped alarm and provoke the British into their 1839 invasion of Afghanistan.

Maharajah Ranjit Singh (1780–1839): The brilliant and wily Sikh ruler, who created a powerful, well-organised and well-ruled Sikh kingdom in the Punjab. In 1797 he had helped Shah Zaman save some cannon lost in the